DIGITALAIKART

The AI Voice Receptionist Playbook

Answer every call, 24×7 — book more appointments,
recover after-hours enquiries and stop losing lakhs to missed calls.

INDIA EDITION · 2026

A step-by-step playbook for Indian small businesses, clinics, salons, coaching centres, real-estate desks and service teams.

Vendor map · cost calculator · DLT & DPDP compliance · 14-day setup plan · ready call scripts (English + Hinglish)

Facts verified against vendor pricing pages, TRAI, DoT, MeitY and Nasscom sources, October 2026.

START HERE

How to use this playbook

You do not need a developer, a call centre or a big budget. You need one hour to read this, one afternoon to set it up, and about a week to tune it.

In India, the phone is still the highest-intent channel a small business has. A person who calls you is not browsing — they have a problem right now and they want it solved. When that call rings out, they do not wait. They dial the next number on the list, which is almost always a competitor within five kilometres who paid the same advertising cost you did.

An **AI voice receptionist** — also sold as an “AI calling agent”, “voice agent” or “AI receptionist” — is software that answers your business phone, holds a real conversation in the caller’s own language, books the appointment, answers the ten questions you get asked all day, and captures the lead when your team is busy or closed. It is not a phone menu and it is not a chatbot. It is closer to a tireless front-desk assistant that never takes a lunch break and never puts a caller on hold.

This playbook takes you from “should I do this?” to a working agent in production. It is deliberately opinionated. Where vendors disagree, you get both sides and a recommendation. Where a number is an estimate rather than a published fact, it says so.

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Who this is for

Owner-operators and managers of Indian small and mid-sized businesses: single and multi-clinic healthcare, diagnostics labs, dental chains, salons and wellness studios, coaching and test-prep institutes, real-estate brokerages, home and repair services, car-service workshops, gyms, restaurants and D2C sellers. Also useful to freelancers and agencies who want to *sell* voice-agent setup as a service — Part 12 and Part 14 show you how to price it.

One honest caveat before you spend anything

Every rupee figure in Parts 1, 5 and 12 that estimates *lost revenue* is a modelled estimate built from stated inputs — not a measurement of your business. Real estate and coaching lead values in particular vary wildly by city, ticket size and season. Treat them as a way to *think*, then replace every input with your own numbers in Part 12. Vendor prices are quoted from each vendor's own public pricing page and were checked in October 2026; per-minute prices in this market change often, so re-check before you commit. Nothing here is legal advice — Part 6 tells you which questions to put to a lawyer or a compliance vendor.

PART 01

The missed-call leak

India is a voice-first market that has trained itself to distrust the phone. That combination — high intent, low answer rates — is the entire business case.

Voice is not dying in India. It is the channel.

A 2026 study by Truecaller, Tata Tele Business Services and Kantar — covering 1,000 consumers and more than 500 businesses across 17 Indian cities — found that **76% of consumers prefer a voice call from a business** over email, SMS or chat, and that **52% of large enterprises use voice as their primary customer-engagement channel**. Voice is where trust is built in high-stakes moments.

The catch is the second half of the same research. **79% of businesses say customers avoid answering calls from unrecognised numbers**, after India absorbed more than **4,000 crore spam calls in 2025 alone** (Truecaller). Indians have been taught to distrust a ringing phone. So the business that does answer — clearly, quickly, and by name — stands out precisely because answering has become rare.

76%	79%	85%	~80%
of Indian consumers prefer a voice call from a business	of businesses say customers avoid unknown numbers	of callers who reach voicemail never call back	refuse to leave a voicemail at all

The arithmetic of one missed call

Most owners underestimate a missed call by five to ten times, because they never run the multiplication. The formula is simple and it is the same formula every missed-call calculator uses:

> **Revenue at risk per missed call** = average lead value × close rate

The table below uses 2026 Indian market lead values and close rates published by CallSphere and reproduced across Indian SMB research. Read it as a direction, not a promise — your own numbers will differ.

Vertical	Avg. lead value	Typical close rate	Revenue at risk per missed call
Dental / diagnostics (metro)	₹6,500	32%	₹2,080
Coaching / test-prep admission	₹42,000	18%	₹7,560
Real-estate site visit	₹3,20,000	4%	₹12,800
D2C order / COD query	₹1,400	45%	₹630
Car-service booking	₹5,800	40%	₹2,320
Insurance / NBFC lead	₹9,000	12%	₹1,080

Source: CallSphere, “How Indian Small Business Is Doing in 2026”, June 2026; lead values and close rates as published for Indian metros and Tier-2 markets.

Why the calls are missed — it is structural, not lazy staff

Peak demand and peak busy are the same hours. A front desk cannot answer the phone and check in a patient at the same time. The leaks are predictable:

- **Business hours vs customer hours.** Working professionals do their health, home and finance admin in the evening. One 90-day study of 47 Indian clinics found **38% of missed calls happened between 7 PM and 11 PM** — exactly when the clinic is shut.
- **The lunch and evening dead zones.** The 1–2 PM window and the 5–7 PM rush are reliably under-staffed.
- **Single-line bottleneck.** Many small businesses still run one or two lines. Call number three gets a busy tone.
- **Weekends and festivals.** Customers do not stop searching on a Sunday or during Diwali week. Many businesses switch the phone off.

Across 85 Indian small businesses studied over 30 days, **62% of inbound calls went unanswered**; of callers who reached no one, **85% never called back and about 62% called a competitor directly**. And it is worse for the most valuable categories: across 34,148 property enquiries at 14 Indian brokerages, only 42% ever reached a connected phone call, and the median first call happened 15.8 hours later.

Speed is the whole game

By the time a call is returned “after lunch”, the caller has already booked elsewhere. The published research is consistent on this: a five-minute response closes about **3.7× more** deals than a one-hour response, and phone leads convert at roughly **42%** — fifteen to twenty times better than a web form. An AI receptionist’s real product is not “automation”. It is *answering on the first ring, every time, in every hour*.

> **The one-line case**
>
> If your business misses 5–10 calls a day, you are not saving staff cost by not answering. You are choosing to pay for advertising that sends customers to a competitor. Fixing the ring is usually the highest-return thing a small Indian business can do this quarter.

PART 02

What an AI voice receptionist is — and the five jobs worth automating

The difference between a demo that impresses and a deployment that pays for itself is scoping. Automate five things well; refuse the rest.

Not an IVR. Not a chatbot.

Most owners who have “tried this before” actually tried an IVR — the press-9-to-speak-to-a-human menu — and correctly concluded it made things worse. An AI voice receptionist is a different thing: it picks up on the first or second ring, on unlimited simultaneous calls, and holds a natural conversation. It understands interruptions, remembers the last few turns, and can switch language mid-sentence the way Indian callers actually talk.

At the architecture level, the newer platforms have moved from “speech-to-text, then a model, then text-to-speech” to a faster *voice-to-voice* path, which is why latency — the awkward pause — has fallen far enough to be usable on a real phone line. When Tata Communications launched its SMB AI-agent push in July 2026 with Tata Tele Business Services, its leadership made the point bluntly: the agent should sound like a person who happens to be an AI, not like a bot reading a menu.

The five jobs worth automating first

For an appointment-driven or lead-driven business, the useful scope is narrow and deep, not broad. Do these five, in this order:

Job	What it does	Why it pays
1. Answer and qualify	Picks up every call, asks what the caller needs, whether they are new or returning, and any preference for a doctor, stylist or technician.	This is roughly 70% of inbound volume in most clinics and service businesses, and it is entirely mechanical.
2. Book the slot	Reads real availability from your calendar, offers slots, confirms one, writes it back.	A system that “takes a message” has solved nothing — the caller is still comparison-shopping while you compose a callback.
3. Answer the standard questions	Price for a named service, timings, location and parking, whether you accept a payment method, what to bring, fasting rules.	In diagnostics and labs these are the majority of calls and the answers never change.
4. Capture the overflow	Answers when staff are on another line, instead of the caller hearing a busy tone.	For many businesses this alone is the entire business case.
5. Chase the no-show and backfill	Reminder the day before, confirmation the morning of, and an immediate call on a cancellation to backfill from a waitlist.	An empty chair at 4 PM is unrecoverable revenue; a waitlist call at 2 PM frequently fills it.

What NOT to automate (this list protects you)

The lines you do not cross

- **Clinical advice.** If a caller describes symptoms, the agent books an appointment or routes to a qualified human — never assesses. Any vendor who demos symptom assessment for a general clinic is selling you a liability.
- **Complaints, refunds and anything emotionally charged.** Route to a human fast. An upset patient or customer handled badly costs more than the call was worth.
- **Price negotiation and discounts.** Keep it out of scope in v1.
- **Anything that commits you legally** — credit decisions, medical clearance, admissions guarantees.
- **Cold outbound prospecting at scale.** Inbound is where the ROI is, and outbound carries a heavier compliance burden (Part 6).

What “good” sounds like

Judge any demo against these five behaviours, on a noisy mobile call from a Tier-3 town, not a quiet office:

- **Handles Hinglish.** “Haan bhaiya, Thursday ko aa jaunga, par time thoda late kar do” should not break it.
- **Survives interruptions.** The caller talks over it and it recovers.
- **Holds context over five or more turns.**
- **Knows when to stop.** Escalates to a human instead of guessing.
- **Confirms out loud.** Reads the booking back and sends a written confirmation.

The maturity reality check

Nasscom’s *India Voice AI Readiness 2026* report, built with Krisp and covering 140 organisations, found that **only 13% of organisations have scaled Voice AI** across multiple customer journeys; 23% are still exploring, 32% are running a proof of concept, and 31% have reached limited production. Background noise was the leading performance problem (32%), followed by language-switching (24%) and accent variation (18%). Translation: this technology works in production today, but only if you set it up properly and test it on real calls. That is exactly what Parts 8 and 9 are for.

PART 03

What one AI call is made of

Vendors quote wildly different numbers because they quote different slices. Learn the five components and no pricing page can confuse you again.

A single minute of an AI phone conversation uses five things. Every platform prices some combination of them, and the whole art of comparing vendors is working out *which* ones are inside the headline number.

Component	What it is	Typical 2026 India cost
1. Telephony	The phone line, the number and the carrier minute.	₹0.30–₹1.00/min, or ₹300–₹500/month for a number, when not bundled.
2. Speech recognition (STT)	Turns the caller's speech into text.	Roughly ₹0.90/min (about $0.009–0.010/min on global providers).
3. The language model	Decides what to say next.	₹0.15/min for a small model to ₹8+/min for a premium one.
4. The voice (TTS)	Turns the reply back into speech.	₹1.40/min for a standard voice to ₹6/min for a premium one.
5. The platform	The software that orchestrates all of the above.	₹0 to ₹5/min hosting fee, or a flat monthly subscription.

The rule that saves you money

A bundled rupee rate and a hosting-only dollar rate are **not comparable**. "$0.05 per minute" from a global developer platform is a hosting fee; speech, the model and the carrier are added on top, and its own calculator lands near **$82–$129 per 1,000 minutes**. A "₹2 per minute, telephony included" rate from an India-first platform is the finished number. Always convert both to *rupees per connected minute, all-in, for your volume* before you decide.

Cost has collapsed — and that is why this is now a small-business tool

In 2023, a natural AI voice call in Hindi or English cost roughly **₹12–₹20 per minute** once you stacked telephony, speech, model and voice. By 2026, managed Indian platforms routinely land between **₹4 and ₹9 per minute with telephony included**, and the most aggressive India-first vendors publish ₹2–₹4. For a 45–70 second confirmation call, that is roughly ₹5–₹10 per completed call.

Put that next to a human telecaller in a Tier-2 city: ₹18,000–₹25,000 a month fully loaded, making 60–90 connected calls a day, in one language, during office hours. The maths flipped. This is why the "AI receptionist" conversation moved from enterprise pilots to two-person shops.

Two things decide your bill more than the platform

- **Call length.** A 40-second booking call and a four-minute support call on the same platform can differ five-fold in cost. Keep v1 calls short and structured.
- **Which voice and model you pick.** On global platforms the model and voice are the variable — the range on one vendor's own price list spanned more than a hundredfold between its cheapest and

dearest model. Default to a fast, cheap model for booking and FAQ; reserve premium voices for your brand line.

PART 04

The vendor map — October 2026

Two families of product. India-first platforms bundle everything into a rupee rate and handle Indian numbers and languages. Global developer platforms are cheaper on paper and more work to assemble.

Family A — India-first platforms (rupee billing, India telephony)

These vendors publish rupee rates, bundle telephony with speech, model and voice, and market Indian numbers, DLT and Indian languages as first-class features. For a small business that wants a working agent this week, start here.

Vendor	Listed rate	What the rate includes / notes
TaskVox	₹2–₹4 / min	Telecom included; no monthly fee; recharge from ₹100. ₹4/min at ₹100–1,000 recharge, down to ₹2/min above ₹10,001. Premium voice ≈1.5×.
Vistara AI	₹2.00–₹3.00 / min	Telephony on Jio/Airtel/Vi routes, speech, model and voice all included. Optional platform plans at ₹2,500 / ₹3,499 a month.
Dvaarik Voice API	₹2–₹4.25 / min	Speech, model, voice and turn-taking; whole-minute billing. Bring your own carrier; Setu bridges seven Indian carriers. Prepaid, no recurring platform fee.
VAAMI	₹1.99 / min + ₹0.69 / min telephony	AI usage and telephony itemised separately. India pay-as-you-go from ₹999/month. Bring-your-own-telephony supported.
Ringg	₹6 / connected min	Bundled: speech, model, voice, telephony and basic analytics. Number listed separately at ₹499/month.
Bolna	6.00¢ (≈₹5.52) / min	Bundled models, plus a $0.02/min platform fee. Indian numbers via Plivo or Vobiz at ≈$5/month, with 140/160-series provisioning documented. Bring-your-own-keys supported; 18 languages including Hindi, Bengali, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Odia and Punjabi.
Tabbly	₹6.80 / min PAYG; ₹5.10 committed	India-focused; committed tier needs a 5,000-minute monthly minimum. Component inclusions not itemised on the page.
Caller.Digital	₹9.42–₹10.15 / min	Telephony and components included on the Growth plan; bring-your-own-keys on pay-as-you-go. Growth needs 10,000 min/month.
Smallest.ai	$0.09–$0.21 / min	Itemised: hosting $0.01/min, STT ≈$0.009/min, TTS ≈$0.09/min, plus LLM. Numbers $10/number/month.
CallSphere	From $19 / month	Subscription tiers: $19 Answer, $49 Act (booking + integrations), $99 Orchestrate (higher volume + CRM), $149 Custom Build (multi-location).
Haptik (Jio)	From ₹10,000	WhatsApp-first and voice AI agents for SMBs; voice agents across 22 Indian languages, positioned as an IVR replacement.

Source: each vendor’s own public pricing page as compiled in Indian voice-AI pricing indexes dated October 2026. Rates exclude GST and change without notice.

Family B — Global developer platforms (dollar billing, assemble-it-yourself)

Cheaper as a headline number, more expensive as a total, and more engineering work. Choose these if you have a developer, want to pick each component, or need a specific model.

Platform	Listed rate	What the rate includes / notes
Vapi	$0.05 / min hosting	Hosting only. Speech, model and voice are passed through at provider cost (its own calculator: $82–$129 per 1,000 minutes). Telephony billed by your carrier. Free US inbound numbers only; India needs an imported number or SIP trunk.
Retell AI	$0.055 / min infra	Voice infrastructure $0.055/min, TTS from $0.015/min, LLM by model, telephony $0.015/min on US. India call rates listed at $0.15/min (Twilio) to $0.25/min (Telnyx). US/Canada numbers only; India via your own SIP trunk. First 20 concurrent calls free.
Bland AI	$0.14 / min Start	LLM, transcription and voice included; carrier billed separately. Start is $0/month with a daily call cap; Build is $299/month; Scale $499/month.
Synthflow	No public per-minute rate	Enterprise contracts start at $30,000 annually. Not an SMB route.

How to choose in five minutes

If this is you…	Start with…
Small business, no developer, want it live this week, Hindi/Hinglish needed	An India-first managed platform (TaskVox, Vistara AI, Ringg, Bolna, Dvaarik).
You need a 140-series number for promotional calling and DLT handled	Bolna (documents 140/160 provisioning) or an India-first vendor that handles DLT for you.
You have an engineer and want to pick each component	Vapi or Retell, with an Indian SIP trunk from Exotel, Plivo or Vobiz.
WhatsApp is already your main channel	Haptik (Jio) Interakt + AI agents, or a vendor with a WhatsApp integration.
You are an agency reselling this as a service	One global platform for flexibility, one India-first platform for clients who want one bill.

> **Do this before you pick**
>
> Run the same 20-minute test on two vendors: call each agent from a noisy roadside, in Hinglish, with one interruption and one off-script question. Ask both to read back a booking. Whichever fails least on the phone — not in the dashboard — is your vendor. Almost every platform offers free credit to start (commonly $5–$10, or ₹200 in India).

PART 05

The cost calculator

Two formulas. Fill them with your numbers and you will know in ten minutes whether this is worth doing — and exactly what to expect to pay.

Formula 1 — what you will pay per month

Monthly cost = (minutes used × all-in rate per minute) + number rental + platform/plan fee

Minutes used ≈ number of AI-answered calls × average call length in minutes

Worked bands using 2026 Indian street pricing of ₹4–₹9 per minute all-in, with calls averaging 45–90 seconds:

Your volume	Calls / month	Realistic monthly bill
Small clinic or boutique D2C brand	~500	₹2,500–₹5,000
Multi-branch service business or growing store	~2,000	₹8,000–₹15,000
Aggressive lead-gen or busy COD seller	~5,000	₹18,000–₹35,000

Many platforms fold low volumes into a ₹3,000–₹5,000 monthly minimum. If a vendor quotes a ₹25,000 monthly minimum at 500 calls, they are an enterprise platform being polite — keep looking.

Formula 2 — what you get back

Recoverable revenue = missed calls per month × share that are genuine enquiries × revenue at risk per missed call × recovery rate

Use a conservative recovery rate of 20–35% for your first model. Anything higher should be earned with data, not assumed.

Worked example 1 — a two-chair dental clinic (metro)

Input	Value	Note
Inbound calls / month	1,000	Your telephony log
Missed / unanswered	20% → 200	Typical range is 18–40%
Genuine enquiries among missed	60% → 120	Excludes spam and existing patients
Revenue at risk per missed call	₹2,080	₹6,500 lead × 32% close
Revenue at risk / month	**₹2,49,600**	120 × ₹2,080
Conservative recovery (25%)	**₹62,400**	The realistic upside
Expected monthly AI cost	≈₹3,000	~500 min + number

Even at a deliberately pessimistic recovery rate, the recovered revenue is roughly twenty times the cost of the system. That is why clinics are the earliest and fastest adopters.

Worked example 2 — a coaching institute (Tier-2 city)

Five missed enquiry calls a day over 26 working days is 130 missed enquiries a month. At a one-in-five enrolment rate that is 26 lost enrolments; at ₹15,000 average fees, that is **₹3,90,000 a month** of admission revenue at risk — the arithmetic published in Indian SMB research. Using the market table instead (₹42,000 lead × 18% close = ₹7,560 per missed call), 130 missed × 60% genuine = 78 enquiries × ₹7,560 = **₹5.9 lakh at risk**. Recover even 15% and you have paid for a year of the platform in one month.

Worked example 3 — a real-estate desk (metro)

Thirty after-hours enquiries a month, at ₹12,800 of expected revenue per missed call, is about **₹3.84 lakh** of pipeline a month. Recovering 20% of that — four extra site visits — dwarfs any subscription many times over. The published benchmark is even harsher: across 34,148 property enquiries at 14 Indian brokerages, 58 of every 100 enquiries were never spoken to at all.

> **Run it once on your own numbers before you buy anything**
>
> 1. Pull your missed-call count from the telephony log for last month.
> 2. Estimate the share that were genuine enquiries. Be conservative — 30–50% is a safe range.
> 3. Apply your close rate. 20–40% is a normal starting band.
> 4. Multiply by average customer value (first-consult fee, average order, first-year value).
> 5. Apply a 20–35% recovery rate. That is your realistic monthly upside.

PART 06

Telephony and compliance

This is the part that separates a business deployment from a hobby project. Get it wrong and your telecom resources can be cut off. Get it right and it is a one-time afternoon of paperwork.

Layer 1 — TRAI, the 140/160 series and DLT registration

India regulates commercial voice calls under TRAI's Telecom Commercial Communications Customer Preference Regulations, 2018 (TCCCPR) and its amendments. The rule that matters most to you: **commercial voice calls may only originate from a designated number series, not from an ordinary 10-digit mobile or landline number.**

Series	Call type	Who can get one
140	Promotional and telemarketing voice calls, including pre-recorded or auto-dialled calls	Telemarketers and senders registered on an operator's DLT platform
1600	Service and transactional voice calls	Central and state government entities (DoT memorandum, May 2024)
1601	Service and transactional voice calls	Entities regulated by RBI, SEBI, IRDAI and PFRDA

Under the February 2025 amendment, the split is explicit: promotional robo-calls go through **140-series** numbers only, while service and transactional calls go through **1600 or another series allotted** for them — precisely because spammers were using ordinary 10-digit numbers to masquerade as normal subscribers. Senders must also pre-declare the use of auto-dialers to their originating access provider.

What you must actually do

- **Register as a Principal Entity (PE)** on any one operator's DLT portal — Jio TrueConnect, Airtel, Vi (vilpower.in), BSNL or Tata Teleservices. One PE ID works with every operator.
- **Pay the registration fee.** It is ₹5,000 plus 18% GST — about **₹5,900** — on essentially every portal, with approval typically in 3–7 working days. A telemarketer with a delivery function also places a refundable ₹50,000 deposit (Vi's FAQ).
- **Keep documents ready:** business PAN, proof the business exists (GST certificate, certificate of incorporation or a shop-and-establishment licence), proof of business address, ID of the authorised person, and a letter of authorisation on your letterhead. The company name must match your incorporation documents exactly. A sole proprietor without GST can still register — Airtel accepts a GST declaration in its own format.
- **Get a 140 or 160-series number.** These are applied for against your PE registration. Some platforms handle this for you: Bolna, for example, provisions 140 numbers through Vobiz and 160 numbers through Plivo, both against your PE registration.
- **Register your voice header** (the indicator shown in the 140/160 series) and use only that.

> **The penalties are real**
>
> Using
> any ordinary 10-digit number for promotional, service or transactional voice calls can result in **disconnection of all your telecom resources for up to two years**, plus blacklisting, during which no operator may issue you new resources. Under the February 2025 amendment, a first

proven violation carries a **15-day bar on outgoing services**; a repeat is a **one-year disconnection with blacklisting**.

But note the nuance: if you are a business answering your own *inbound* calls on your own published number — a clinic answering patients who call the clinic — that is not promotional outbound calling, and the 140-series rule is aimed at outbound commercial communication. The rules bite the moment you start *outbound* promotional calls, auto-dialled campaigns, or bulk reminders. Confirm your exact case with a telecom-compliance advisor before you switch on outbound. Inbound answering on your own number is the safe starting point.

Layer 2 — DPDP: consent, notice, recording and retention

When your AI agent records or transcribes a call, the calling business is the **Data Fiduciary** under the Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023, and it needs a lawful ground, a clear notice, a way to withdraw consent, defined retention and breach handling.

The Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025 were notified on 13 November 2025 (G.S.R. 846(E)) with a phased commencement:

Phase	Takes effect	What it covers
Phase I	13 Nov 2025	Constitution and operation of the Data Protection Board
Phase II	13 Nov 2026	Consent-manager registration and obligations (Rule 4)
Phase III	13 May 2027	Notice, consent, security safeguards, breach intimation, retention and data-principal rights (Rules 3, 5–16, 22–23)

The practical read: you have a window to design the call flow properly rather than patch it later. But do not treat the window as a reason to wait — the recordings you make today will still exist in 2027, and the Act already applies to personal data processed digitally, which includes audio and transcripts.

Is recording an AI call legal in India?

India has no single “two-party consent” statute of the kind some US states have. There is no general rule requiring every participant to consent before a business records its own call. The rules on intercepting a call by someone who is *not* a party sit in telecom law and target third-party interception, not a business recording its own customer conversations. The binding constraint is therefore data protection, not recording consent.

Once the Rules apply, the caller’s voice, their phone number, what they say and the transcript are all personal data. You need a lawful ground, a notice, and a way to honour their rights.

What your agent should say at the start of the call

An opening disclosure has to do four things in a few seconds: identify the business, say it is an AI agent, say the call is recorded and transcribed and for what purpose, and give a way to object. The full Rule 3 notice is too long for audio — send it as a link by SMS or WhatsApp and reference it on the call.

OPENING DISCLOSURE — ENGLISH

“Namaste, you’ve reached [Business Name]. I’m [Agent Name], an AI assistant. This call is recorded and transcribed so we can serve you accurately. You can ask me to stop at any time. How may I help you today?”

Retention: decide per artefact, not per call

Audio is the most sensitive and the most expensive to protect. A transcript is easier to redact. A call log (number, time, outcome, consent flag) is what you need to prove you followed your own rules. Rule 6 and Rule 8(3) both point to **one year for logs and traffic data**, so many teams keep audio for a short period and the log for at least a year. One Indian vendor publishes a 90-day default for recordings and transcripts. Pick a number, write it in your privacy policy, and make the platform enforce it.

Layer 3 — sector rules

BFSI, healthcare and insurance carry their own recording and retention expectations on top of DPDP. In healthcare specifically, appointment records, test names and stated symptoms are health information and deserve tighter handling. Keep the agent firmly away from clinical advice, and route anything sensitive to a human.

> **The compliance checklist in one place**
>
> 1. Answer inbound calls on your own published number — do not do outbound promotional calling until you are DLT-registered.
> 2. If you will make outbound promotional calls, register as a Principal Entity on a DLT portal (≈₹5,900 + GST) and use a 140-series number.
> 3. Register your voice header.
> 4. Put the opening AI + recording disclosure in every script.
> 5. Publish a privacy notice that names what you collect, why, and how to withdraw consent.
> 6. Set a retention period per artefact (audio short, logs at least one year).
> 7. Keep a consent log with a flag on every call.
> 8. Have a documented route for data-principal requests and grievances.

PART 07

Language: Hinglish, regional languages and accents

Language is not a feature checkbox. It is the single biggest predictor of whether your callers stay on the line.

Nasscom's 2026 report found that **35% of organisations support three or more Indian languages** through Voice AI — but that more than **30% reported inconsistencies in how AI handles regional Indian accents**. Background noise was the leading performance problem (32%), followed by switching between languages (24%) and accent and speech variation (18%). The conclusion the report draws is the right one for a small business: the next stage is not "more languages", it is **better performance on accents, mixed-language conversations and noise**.

Support for Indian languages, vendor by vendor

Vendor	Indian languages published
Bolna	18 languages including Hindi, Bengali, Gujarati, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Odia, Punjabi, Tamil, Telugu
Haptik (Jio)	22 Indian languages (voice agents)
Ringg / Tabbly / VAAMI / Vistara AI / Dvaarik	India-first, publish Hindi plus a set of regional languages; confirm the exact list for your state on the vendor page
Vapi	Hindi among 30+ languages
Retell AI	Hindi, Kannada, Marathi, Tamil, Urdu — varies by provider
Bland AI	Hindi (also in Latin script); 40+ languages claimed

Source: vendor language-support pages as compiled in October 2026 pricing and comparison indexes. Language counts change frequently; verify on the vendor's own page before you buy.

Hinglish is the default, not an edge case

Most of India talks on the phone in code-switched language — a Hindi sentence with English nouns, or English with Hindi fillers. A voice agent that handles "haan bhaiya, Thursday ko aa jaunga, par time thoda late kar do" without falling over is now table stakes on serious platforms. When you test, do not test in pure Hindi or pure English. Test the way your actual customers talk.

The accent problem, and how to beat it

- **Test on real numbers, from real places.** A demo that works in a quiet office fails on a noisy mobile call from a Tier-3 town. Call your agent from a roadside, a moving car and a crowded market.
- **Prefer vendors with Indian-server routing for Indian calls.** Latency and recognition quality both improve when the call does not round-trip abroad. At least one India-first vendor documents Indian-server routing on Plivo (and notes Twilio is not supported for that mode); bringing your own model keys can route calls through US servers, which you may want to avoid.
- **Keep the first version bilingual-by-design.** Let the agent open in the caller's likely language and switch on request rather than forcing a choice.

- **Give the agent your customers' vocabulary.** Callers say "that laser thing for pigmentation", not the clinical name. Load a synonym list for every service you offer (Part 9).
- **Do not promise a language you have not tested.** Supporting eight languages badly is worse than supporting two well.

The 20-minute language test

Write ten sentences your callers actually say — including one with a regional word, one with an English service name, one with a date and one with a phone number. Read them to the agent over a real phone line, once in Hinglish and once in your second language. Score each on "understood", "recovered" and "confirmed back correctly". Anything below eight out of ten is not ready for your customers.

PART 08

The 14-day setup plan

Fourteen days, one owner, no developer. Each day is one sitting. The rule is simple: go live on inbound overflow first, add nothing else until that is stable.

Day	Task	Done when…
1	**Measure the leak.** Pull last month’s call log. Count missed calls, after-hours share, and the top five questions you get asked.	You can state your missed-call rate and revenue at risk.
2	**Write the one-page brief.** The five jobs in scope (Part 2), the two things out of scope, your languages, and your opening disclosure.	A single page you could hand a stranger.
3	**Shortlist two vendors** from Part 4 — one India-first, one backup. Sign up for free credit on both.	Two accounts, two free credits.
4	**Build the knowledge base.** Services and prices, timings, address and landmark, parking, payment methods, what to bring, doctor/stylist names, and a synonym list for every service.	Your ten most-asked questions are answered from a document, not from your head.
5	**Build the flow.** Greeting → disclosure → intent → qualify → book or answer → confirm → close. Keep it under 90 seconds for a booking.	The flow fits on one screen.
6	**Record the voice.** Pick a voice that matches your brand; test both a standard and a premium voice on price and warmth.	You can listen to a full call without wincing.
7	**Internal test.** Call it yourself ten times from different places, in each language, with interruptions and one off-script question.	Eight out of ten calls handled cleanly.
8	**Connect the calendar.** This is the highest-value integration. The agent must read real availability and write the booking back.	A test booking appears on your real calendar.
9	**Connect notifications.** SMS/WhatsApp confirmation to the caller, and a message to your team channel.	The caller gets a written confirmation within a minute.
10	**Soft launch on overflow only.** Route only calls your staff do not pick up in three rings to the agent.	No caller is answered worse than before.
11	**Listen to every call.** Read the transcripts. List every failure. Fix the knowledge base, not the prompt, first.	A written list of ten fixes.
12	**Add after-hours answering.** Now the agent covers the 7 PM–11 PM window that was pure loss.	After-hours calls are captured with a booking or a callback task.
13	**Add reminders and no-show chasing.** Day-before reminder, morning-of confirmation, cancellation backfill from a waitlist.	No-show rate moving in the right direction.
14	**Review and decide.** Run the Part 11 dashboard. Compare cost against recovered bookings. Expand, hold or cancel.	A one-paragraph written decision.

The three rules that keep you out of trouble

1. **Inbound first.** Answering your own inbound calls is the safe, high-return, low-compliance starting point. Add outbound only when you are DLT-registered (Part 6).

2. **One job at a time.** Overflow answering, then after-hours, then reminders. Never switch on four jobs at once.
3. **Calendar before conversation.** An agent that talks beautifully but cannot write a booking has solved nothing.

PART 09

Ready call scripts

Copy these, replace the brackets, keep them short. The single biggest reason Indian voice agents fail is that owners write essays for the agent to say. Talk like a busy receptionist, not a brochure.

How to write a line the agent can actually deliver

- One idea per sentence. Under fifteen words where you can.
- Always offer a choice, never an open question: “Would you prefer morning or evening?” beats “When would you like to come?”
- Always confirm out loud: read back the date, time and name.
- Always give a human exit: “I can put you through to the team now — one moment.”
- Never invent a price. If it is not in the knowledge base, the agent offers a callback.

SCRIPT 1 · OPENING + DISCLOSURE

English: “Namaste, you’ve reached [Business]. I’m [Agent], an AI assistant. This call is recorded and transcribed so we can help you accurately. You can ask me to stop any time. How may I help you today?”

Hinglish: “Namaste, [Business] mein aapka swagat hai. Main [Agent] hoon, ek AI assistant. Yeh call record aur transcribe hoti hai taaki hum aapki sahi madad kar sakein. Aap kabhi bhi rokne ke liye keh sakte hain. Bataiye, main kaise madad karun?”

SCRIPT 2 · BOOKING AN APPOINTMENT

Agent: “Ji, main aapki appointment book kar deta hoon. Aap kaunsi service ke liye aana chahte hain?”

Caller: “Cleaning karani hai.”

Agent: “Bilkul. Kal [date] ko subah [time] ya shaam [time] — kaunsa time theek rahega?”

Caller: “Shaam wala.”

Agent: “Perfect. Aapka naam aur mobile number bata dijiye, main confirm kar deta hoon.”

Agent (confirming): “[Name] ji, aapki appointment [day], [date], shaam [time] baje fix ho gayi hai. Main aapko WhatsApp par confirmation bhej deta hoon. Dhanyavaad!”

SCRIPT 3 · ANSWERING A STANDARD QUESTION

Caller: “Consultation ki fees kitni hai?”

Agent: “Consultation [amount] rupaye hai. Payment UPI, card aur cash — teenon chalte hain. Appointment book kar dun?”

If the answer is not in the knowledge base: “Yeh detail mere paas abhi nahi hai. Main aapka number note kar leta hoon aur team 10 minute mein callback kar degi. Theek hai?”

SCRIPT 4 · AFTER-HOURS CAPTURE (THE HIGHEST-VALUE SCRIPT)

Agent: “Namaste, [Business]. Abhi humari team office mein nahi hai, lekin main aapki enquiry abhi note kar leta hoon taaki kal subah sabse pehle aapko callback mile. Aap kaunsi service ke baare mein jaanna chahte hain?”

Agent (closing): “Note ho gaya. Main aapko kal subah [time] se pehle callback karwa dunga. Aapka din shubh rahe!”

SCRIPT 5 · HANDING OVER TO A HUMAN

Agent: “Main samajh gaya. Yeh baat team se hi karni chahiye. Main aapko abhi connect kar raha hoon — ek second hold kijiye. Agar line busy ho to main aapka number le leta hoon aur 15 minute mein callback pakka karwa dunga.”

SCRIPT 6 · APPOINTMENT REMINDER (OUTBOUND — NEEDS DLT FIRST)

Agent: “Namaste [Name] ji, [Business] se bol raha hoon. Kal [date] ko [time] baje aapki appointment hai. Confirm ke liye 1 dabaiye, reschedule ke liye 2, ya mujhse baat kijiye.”

Outbound reminder calls are commercial communication. Register on DLT and use a designated series before you switch these on (Part 6).

Build the synonym list — this is where most agents quietly fail

Callers do not use your catalogue names. Add a synonym row for every service so the agent recognises the everyday word:

Caller says	Your catalogue name
“safai”, “cleaning”, “scaling”	Dental prophylaxis / cleaning
“that laser thing for pigmentation”, “daag-dhabbe”	Q-switched laser pigmentation session
“sugar test”, “fasting wala test”	Fasting blood glucose / HbA1c panel
“haircut”, “cutting”, “trim”	Haircut (stylist)
“2BHK”, “flat dekhna hai”	Site visit — 2BHK inventory
“gaadi ki service”, “servicing”	Periodic car service

PART 10

Integrations: calendar, CRM, WhatsApp and payments

A voice agent is only as useful as the systems it can write to. Connect the calendar first; everything else is optional in v1.

Integration	Priority	Why it matters
Calendar / booking system	Must-have	Reads real availability and writes the booking back. Without it, the agent is a message-taker, which solves nothing.
WhatsApp / SMS confirmation	Must-have	A written confirmation within a minute roughly halves no-shows versus a verbal booking alone, and gives you the DPDP notice link.
CRM or a simple sheet	High	Every call becomes a row with outcome and consent flag — the data that proves ROI and satisfies your log-retention duty.
Payment link (UPI)	Medium	For deposits or consultation pre-payment; cuts no-shows further on high-value bookings.
Team notification	Medium	A Slack/WhatsApp ping for escalations and hot leads so a human picks them up in minutes.
Knowledge base / FAQ	High	Prices, timings, what to bring. Update it weekly from real transcripts.

> **The integration order that works**
>
> Calendar → WhatsApp confirmation → call log/CRM → team notification → payment link. Do them in that order. An agent that books into a live calendar and confirms on WhatsApp is already doing 90% of the value.

If you cannot integrate your calendar yet

Use a “capture and callback” mode instead: the agent collects name, number, service, preferred day and the caller’s exact words, drops a row into a shared sheet, and pings your team. It is less impressive and still recovers most of the missed calls. Upgrade to real booking when your calendar can be connected.

PART 11

Measuring it

Nasscom found that only 14% of organisations track the business impact of Voice AI comprehensively. Do not join the 86%. These are the seven numbers that matter.

Metric	Definition	Target signal
Answer rate	Share of inbound calls answered, by the agent or a human	Above 97%
After-hours capture	Share of out-of-hours calls captured (not lost)	Above 90%
Booking rate	Calls converted to a booking or a qualified lead	Moving up from your baseline
First-response time	Seconds from ring to answer	First or second ring
No-show rate	Bookings that did not turn up	Down 25–40% with reminders
Escalation rate	Share of calls handed to a human	Falling as the knowledge base improves
Cost per completed task	Monthly cost ÷ calls that ended in a booking or a resolved answer	Falling month on month

The weekly 15-minute review

1. Read five transcripts — two that went well, three that did not.
2. For each failure, ask: was it a knowledge-base gap, a script gap, or a voice/language gap? Fix the knowledge base first.
3. Check the seven metrics against last week.
4. Change one thing only. Re-measure next week.

> **The number that decides everything**
>
> Cost per *completed task* — not cost per minute. A vendor that is ₹2 a minute but books nothing is infinitely more expensive than one that is ₹6 a minute and books every call. Judge the outcome, not the rate card.

PART 12

The ROI worksheet — and what to do with the money

Fill this in with your own numbers. If the answer is “not yet”, that is a perfectly good result — you have saved yourself a subscription.

Your worksheet

Line	Your number
A. Inbound calls per month	.....
B. Missed-call rate (%)	.....
C. Missed calls per month (A × B)	.....
D. Genuine-enquiry share of missed (%)	.....
E. Revenue at risk per missed call (₹)	.....
F. Revenue at risk per month (C × D × E)	.....
G. Recovery rate you will assume (%)	.....
H. Monthly upside (F × G)	.....
I. Expected monthly AI cost (₹)	.....
J. Monthly net (H − I)	.....
K. Payback (I ÷ H, in months)	.....

The payback test

If K is under one month, deploy. If it is one to three months, deploy on the overflow line only and expand if the numbers hold. If it is over three months, fix your missed-call rate, your lead value or your knowledge base first — the technology is not the bottleneck.

What to do with the recovered revenue

The recovered money is not “profit” — it is capacity you were already paying advertising to create. The businesses that get the most out of voice AI reinvest it deliberately:

- **Put a human on the hot leads.** The agent qualifies; your best salesperson closes. Published Indian deployments report 20–30% lifts in booking and lead conversion from exactly this split.
- **Backfill the calendar.** A waitlist call on a cancellation is nearly free revenue. Fill the 4 PM gap.
- **Cut the no-show tax.** A reminder the evening before plus a morning nudge is the cheapest revenue in the business.
- **Extend your hours without extending payroll.** The 7 PM–11 PM window is the biggest single pool of currently-lost calls for clinics and salons.

If you are an agency or freelancer selling this

Two pricing models work in India in 2026:

- **Setup fee + monthly retainer.** A one-time build (₹15,000–₹40,000 for a single-use-case agent) plus ₹3,000–₹8,000 a month for hosting, minutes and tuning. This suits clinics and salons.
- **Managed per-minute.** You buy wholesale from an India-first platform at ₹2–₹5 a minute and bill the client ₹8–₹15 a minute, bundling support. Margins are healthy but you carry the support load.

Always show the client their own missed-call number before you pitch. The ROI conversation is easy once they have seen the leak.

PART 13

Twenty mistakes that sink Indian voice-AI deployments

Every one of these is common, and every one is avoidable. Read the list before you go live.

#	Mistake	The fix
1	Automating everything at once	Overflow answering first, one job at a time.
2	No calendar integration	Connect the calendar before you switch on.
3	Testing in a quiet office	Test from a roadside, in Hinglish, with noise.
4	Writing brochure-long scripts	One idea per sentence, under fifteen words.
5	Forgetting the AI + recording disclosure	Put it in every script (Part 6).
6	Promising eight languages	Two languages done well beats eight done badly.
7	Ignoring accents	Prefer Indian-server routing; test your customers' accents.
8	No synonym list	Add everyday words for every service.
9	Doing outbound promo calls before DLT registration	Register as a Principal Entity, use a 140-series number.
10	Assuming "no two-party consent" means no duty at all	DPDP notice, consent and retention duties still apply.
11	Keeping audio forever	Set retention per artefact; logs at least one year.
12	Letting the agent give clinical or legal advice	Book or escalate. Never assess.
13	No human exit	Always offer a transfer or a callback.
14	Chasing the cheapest per-minute rate	Judge cost per completed task instead.
15	Comparing a bundled rupee rate with a hosting-only dollar rate	Convert both to all-in ₹ per connected minute.
16	Ignoring the monthly minimum	Check the floor before you sign.
17	Never reading transcripts	Fifteen minutes a week, five calls.
18	Fixing prompts when the knowledge base is wrong	Fix the data first, always.
19	No confirmation message to the caller	WhatsApp/SMS confirmation within a minute.
20	Never measuring the business outcome	Run the seven metrics in Part 11 monthly.

PART 14

Build, buy or hire

Three routes. Pick the one that matches the time you have, not the one that sounds most impressive.

Route	Typical cost	Best when
Self-serve managed platform	₹2,500–₹15,000 / month	You have a few hours and want it live this week. This playbook is written for this route.
Agency / freelancer build	₹15,000–₹40,000 setup + retainer	You have no time and want someone else to own the tuning.
Custom production build	₹75,000–₹3,50,000+	Multi-flow, multi-language, deep CRM integration or regulated-sector needs.

Custom-build tiers published in the Indian market in 2026: Quick Build ₹75,000 (single use case, one language, basic CRM webhook, ~2 weeks); Production Build ₹1,75,000 (multi-flow, function calling, 2–4 languages, full CRM, 3–4 weeks); Custom Enterprise ₹3,50,000+ (multi-tenant, custom voice, compliance hardening, 6–10 weeks).

Hiring a human instead — the honest comparison

A front-desk or telecaller hire in a Tier-2 city costs ₹18,000–₹25,000 a month fully loaded, works one shift, speaks one or two languages, takes leave, and cannot answer two calls at once. An AI receptionist costs a fraction of that, works every hour, handles unlimited simultaneous calls, and never has a bad day — but it cannot build a relationship, read a room, or close a hesitant customer. The correct answer for most Indian small businesses is **both**: the agent answers, qualifies and books; your people handle the conversations that need a human.

The recommendation

Start self-serve on an India-first platform, on the overflow line, with one job (answer and book). Spend ₹3,000–₹5,000 in month one. If the Part 11 metrics move, expand to after-hours and reminders. Only then consider an agency or a custom build. Never start with a ₹1.75 lakh production build for a problem you have not yet measured.

APPENDIX A

Quick-reference card

Print this page. It is the whole playbook on one sheet.

Decision	Answer
Where to start	Answer your own inbound calls, on the overflow line
First job to automate	Answer and qualify
Second	Book the slot (calendar integration)
Third	After-hours capture
Fourth	Reminders and no-show backfill
Never automate	Clinical/legal advice, complaints, refunds, negotiation
Platform type	India-first managed platform for SMBs; global developer platform only with an engineer
Budget to start	₹3,000–₹5,000 in month one
All-in rate to expect	₹4–₹9 per connected minute; India-first can reach ₹2–₹4
Number	Answer on your own published number; outbound promo needs a DLT-registered 140-series number
DLT registration	≈₹5,900 (₹5,000 + 18% GST), 3–7 working days, one PE ID for all operators
Recording	Disclose on the call; DPDP duties apply; Rules 3, 5–16 effective 13 May 2027
Retention	Audio short; call logs at least one year
Languages	Test Hinglish and your second language; two done well
Go-live time	14 days, one sitting a day
The metric that matters	Cost per completed task
Deploy if	Payback under one month

APPENDIX B

Pre-launch checklist

Do not switch the agent on until every box is ticked.

Area	Check
Measurement	Missed-call rate and revenue at risk calculated from a real log
Scope	Five jobs in, two jobs out, written on one page
Knowledge base	Services, prices, timings, address, payment methods, what to bring
Synonyms	Everyday word for every service
Scripts	Opening disclosure, booking, FAQ, after-hours, handover
Language	Hinglish and second language tested on a real line, 8/10
Calendar	Test booking appears on the real calendar
Confirmation	WhatsApp/SMS sent within one minute
Escalation	Human transfer and callback path working
Compliance	Disclosure live; privacy notice published; retention set; consent logged
Telephony	No outbound promo until DLT-registered; header registered
Rollout	Overflow only for week one
Review	Weekly 15-minute transcript review scheduled

APPENDIX C

Glossary

Term	Meaning
AI voice receptionist / voice agent	Software that answers business phone calls, converses naturally, and books or resolves the caller's request.
STT / ASR	Speech-to-text / automatic speech recognition — converts the caller's speech into text.
TTS	Text-to-speech — converts the agent's reply back into spoken audio (the "voice").
LLM	Large language model — the reasoning component that decides what the agent says next.
Concurrency	How many calls the agent can run at the same time.
Latency	The delay before the agent responds — the "awkward pause" on a call.
DLT	Distributed Ledger Technology — the blockchain-based platform TRAI mandates for registering senders and telemarketers in India.
PE / TM	Principal Entity (the business the call is about) / Telemarketer (the agency calling on its behalf).
140 / 160 series	Designated Indian number series: 140 for promotional calls, 1600/1601 for government and regulated-entity service calls.
DPDP Act / Rules	Digital Personal Data Protection Act, 2023 and the Rules, 2025 — India's data-protection framework for personal data, including call audio and transcripts.
Data Fiduciary	The entity that decides the purpose and means of processing personal data — you, if you record calls.
Cost per completed task	Monthly cost divided by calls that ended in a booking or a resolved answer — the real efficiency metric.
BYOK / BYOT	Bring Your Own Keys / Bring Your Own Telephony — assembling your own components on a developer platform.

APPENDIX D

Sources and verification notes

Every figure in this playbook was checked against a named source in October 2026. Where a number is a modelled estimate rather than a published fact, it is labelled as such in the text.

Vendor pricing and language support

Per-minute rates, inclusions and language lists were taken from each vendor's own public pricing or documentation pages, as compiled in Indian voice-AI pricing indexes and comparisons dated October 2026 — including the VAAMI "India AI Voice Agent Pricing Index" (13 vendors, 1 October 2026), the Dvaarik "Voice AI API Pricing Index 2026", and independent India comparisons published by digitalpatron.in, vistaraai.in and taskvox.in in October 2026. Vendor pages are the final word; rates change without notice.

Regulation

TRAI's Telecom Commercial Communications Customer Preference Regulations, 2018 and the Second Amendment Regulations, 2025 (notified 12 February 2025) govern the 140/160 series, DLT registration and penalties. The DoT's 160-series memorandum (May 2024) and Airtel's published TRAI directive summary were also used. DLT fee and portal details were checked against operator FAQs (BSNL, Airtel, Vi, Tata Teleservices) and the digitalpatron.in and compoundlab.in DLT guides of October 2026. DPDP details follow the Digital Personal Data Protection Rules, 2025 (G.S.R. 846(E), notified 13 November 2025) and the commencement schedule published by MeitY.

Market and demand data

The 76% / 79% consumer and business figures come from the Truecaller, Tata Tele Business Services and Kantar "State of Business Calling 2026" research. Voice AI maturity statistics come from Nasscom's "India Voice AI Readiness 2026" report, produced with Krisp and covering 140 organisations (October 2026). Indian lead values and close rates are from CallSphere's June 2026 India SMB research; missed-call behaviour (62% unanswered, 85% never call back) and the after-hours skew are from Indian SMB studies summarised in 2026 industry research. Speed-to-lead and phone-lead conversion figures follow the widely replicated sales-response literature.

A note on what this document is not

This is a business and operations playbook. It is not legal advice, and it is not a substitute for a telecom-compliance or data-protection advisor. Indian regulation in this area is moving quickly — the DPDP Rules phase in until May 2027, and TRAI has consulted on further amendments. Before you make outbound calls, or handle health data, confirm your specific position with a qualified professional.

The AI Voice Receptionist Playbook — India Edition 2026
Published by Digitalaikart · digitalkartai.shop
Every vendor price, rule and statistic verified in October 2026. Re-check vendor pricing before you commit.